

THE OPEN SQUELCH

QUARTERLY JOURNAL OF THE VAN WERT, OHIO AMATEUR RADIO CLUB
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SATURDAY MORNING NET

The Saturday morning net has been in existence for as long as I have been involved with the VWARC. This net has been the meeting place for many hams in our area. But over the years the importance of this net seems to have diminished in the minds of many of our club members as well as amateurs in the area. The net would last as long as two hours on many occasions. And at one time one person was the net control every Saturday.

What has brought about the lack of interest in the net? I know that since the tornado destroyed our house, November 10, 2002, until we got into our new house, December 4, 2003, I have neglected getting on and taking part. Hopefully I can again be active in this net.

The number of net control operators also seems to have slid back into the cracks. The list consists of only seven amateurs. So every seven weeks they have their turn. I think I have made it relative easy to help operators to be net control by typing out the preamble and closing statements that can be used. They are not the "law" but only suggestions to help. I schedule net operators for the whole year, but am willing to add anybody that would like to help at any time. Nothing has been permanently burned in. Changes can be made!

Being the net operator gives the opportunity to practice your preparedness should an event occur, such as the tornado, for handling communication during an emergency. Things can certainly get hectic and you must react quickly and in an orderly manner. This can make a good or poor impression on the agencies we assist.

I invite all area amateurs, both members and non-members of the VWARC to contact me to put your name on the roster. I am willing to list it for even just one week. You pick the date or dates. Also I invite all to check in on the net every Saturday morning at 10:30 am local time. Let's not let this net fall into the cracks!

If you have any suggestions to help improve this net, please let me know. You can reach me at 419.238.1664 or by email at rfs1ham@juno.com. '73's!

-----by Ralph Shields, WB8YIH

FIELD DAY 2004

Field day for 2004 is just around the corner. Last year the VWRAC held field day at the EOC for our EMA office to compete in the newly formed Class F. Our club captured first place in the nation last year. We are the defending winners!

Class F was established to let an amateur radio station at an established Emergency Operations Center (EOC) site be activated allowing utilization of the existing equipment and antennas as well as

equipment temporarily installed for the event. An EOC is defined as a facility established by a Federal, State, County, City or other Civil Government, with which the local amateur group has an established operating arrangement. A Class F operation must take place in cooperation with the staff of the EOC being activated. Class F stations are eligible for all bonus points under Field Day rule 7.3.

Last year we temporarily installed antennas for the CW station (whatever that is) and 40-meter phone station. If you got tired or hot you were able to cool off in the EOC building where all the food was kept and minus all the bugs. MUCH, MUCH NICER!

This year we are going to operate Field Day again as Class 4 F and will be held **June 26-27, 2004**, beginning at 1800 UTC (2:00 PM EDT) Saturday and ending 24 hours later on Sunday. Setup of the temporary stations will take place after 2:00 PM on Friday.

Come on out and enjoy Field Day 2004 and enjoy the food, fun and fellowship!

Ralph WB8YIH
EC Van Wert County

Peony Parade help needed

It's an annual tradition: the Peony Festival and Parade, and W8FY is part of the tradition, and it all takes place this Saturday, June 3rd, 2004.

For many years, the radio club has assisted the Van Wert Police Department along the parade route. The math is simple: the Peony Parade is a grand event that covers a lot of territory, and the police cannot be everywhere. There are 34 points along the parade route that the police would like to have coverage; officers will cover 17 of those points, and police Lt. Tom Bartz has asked that we cover the remaining 17 intersections and possibly a ham at the police/fire station.

The traditional pre-parade briefing will be held at city council chambers at the Municipal Building on East Main Street, Van Wert, at 3:15 pm. The meeting is expected to last less than 30 minutes, so all units can be at their assigned stations by 4:00. At that time, crews will begin to close off the intersections to car traffic. That task takes all of 30 minutes, so if all goes according to plan, the streets will be closed one half hour prior to the start of the parade.

As always, our task is to be the eyes and ears of the police in the event of any emergency situation. Most of the time, we just enjoy the parade like every one else, but a few times in the past our communications equipment and skills as operators came through in emergency situations during the parade. Let's all hope we can just be on stand by just watch the floats go by.

Also fast becoming a tradition with the radio club is sitting down for food and fellowship at the clubhouse after the parade and before the Saturday evening regular meeting. So charge up those batteries for your HT, don your club shirt, hat and vest, and we'll see you Saturday.

-----by Jack Snyder, WD8MLV

2004	VWARC CALENDAR	2 Mtr Net
Jun 5 ...	Peony Festival Parade in VW, everyone and their 2 Mtr rig, 3:00 at PD; Parade 5:00	Jun 5
AFTER	Check in on 2 meters, bring a friend (wit rig) we can use 20 operators! ya'll cumen eat! V	WD8MLV
PARADE ->	Food at Club, thanks to Barb N8GFK, then VWARC Meeting at 8:00 PM	Jun 12
	Field Day and Hamfest discussion before the meeting, they are just 1 and 2 months away!	KC8RYS
also ->	** Hamfest; Wabash, IN Jun 6 ** IARU & RSGB FD ** QRP TAC Sprint**	Jun 19
Jun 12-14	ARRL June VHF QSO Party Hamfest; Wauseon, June 13	WD8LPY
		Jun 26
Jun 19 ...	*** KID'S DAY OPERATING EVENT, get a kid on Ham Radio, 1800-2400Z (2-8 PM) ***	KH6ILT
Jun 19 ..=>	DELPHOS Firemans Association Convention; They need you and your Handheld!	
Jun 19 ...	VWARC Meeting at EMA Office, 8:00 PM. / Field Day Meeting at 7:30 **Just a Week Away!	
	* Hamfests Milford, OH June 19, Midland, MI June 19 Monroe, MI June 20	
	also WV QSO Party; SMIRK QSO Party (6 meter) All-Asian CW test	
Jun 25 ...	Field Day setup starts at 1800 UTC or 2:00 PM, there is fun for everyone, we need YOU! Operate!	
Jun 26-27	Field Day VWARC will be at the EMA Office operating 4-F W8FY, CQFD, CQFD	5 Rigs, no
CQFD	FOOD, CW, PACKET, SSB, FUN, GOTA, SOLAR, FOOD, and for the whole family!	Waiting! ?
Jul 1 ...	July 1st. Canada Day Contest, (all day)	
Jul 3 ...	VWARC Meeting at EMA Office, 8:00 PM. / Hamfest Meeting at 7:30 everyone is welcome	Jul 3
Jul 4 ...	MI QRP July 4th Sprint ** Original QRP Test ** Venezuelan Ind. Day SSB/CW	WB8YIH
		Jul 10
Jul 5 ...	VW HOLIDAY at HOME; VWARC will set up at Museum plus Parade in morning AND	KC8QHK
	BICYCLE TOUR of VW Co at 7:30 AM(we can ride in truck?)or BYOB! bring your own	Jul 17
	Need your help for Caboose SE & Parade & Bike Tour etc. ***** BIKE!	W8DHG
Jul 4-5	VWARC Special Event ** both days from 1500-2300Z at Museum and Club ! HELP !	Jul 24
Jul 10-11	IARU HF World Championship, also ARCI and FISTS Sprints *Hamfest Bowling Green 7/11*	N8OSO
		Jul 31
Jul 17 ==>	VWARC MEETING AT THE FAIR GROUND, IT'S SETUP TIME FOR HAMFEST 2004	WD8MLV
	STARTING AT 6:30 PM ** Hamfest Wellington, OH **	
Jul 18	VWARC HAMFEST ! Tell everyone, on the air and wherever you may be	Hamfest
Hamfest	to be there, they will thank you for it ,we all will ! HAMFEST 03 bethere	2004
2004	EXAMS Van Wert HAMFEST Contact Bob, KA8IAF for info 419-795-5763 (pre-register)	Sun July, 18
Jul 24	Hamfests; Cincinnati, OH-KY-IN July, 24 Portage, OH Jul 25	
also->	IOTA Contest, Russian RTTY	
Jul 30-31	FARM FOCUS and we will have a chance to help starting with set up on JULY 28th	Aug 7
Aug 7	VWARC Meeting at EMA Office, 8:00 PM. / Hamfest Meeting at 7:30 everyone is welcome	KC8RYS
also->	HAMFEST; Columbus, Aug 7; Contests, 10-10 Int. SSB; ARRL UHF; NA QSO Party CW	Aug 14
		WD8LPY
Aug 14-15	Maryland-DC QSO Party / WAE DX Contest CW *Hamfest Warren, OH 8/15*	Aug 21
Aug 21	VWARC Meeting at EMA Office, 8:00 PM. / Plans for Fair (you can help)!	KH6ILT
also->	NJ QSO Party; + NA QSO Party SSB + SEANET WW DX, + Keyman ;Japan test	Aug 28
		WB8YIH
	EXAMS Van Wert EMA 2:00 Contact Bob, KA8IAF for info 419-795-5763 (pre-register)	
Aug 28-29	**Ohio QSO Party (let's get VW County on the air; W8FY for sure!)* + Hawaii QSO P	Sep 4
Sep 1-		KC8QHK
thru Sep 8	VAN WERT COUNTY FAIR; plan to help VWARC in the booth and at the activities.	Sep 11
		W8DHG
Sep 4	VWARC Meeting at EMA Office, 8:00 PM. / Hamfest Meeting at 7:30 everyone is welcome	Sep 18
Sep 18	VWARC Meeting at EMA Office, 8:00 PM. / Field Day Meeting at 7:30	N8OSO
Sep 25	EXAMS Van Wert EMA 2 PM Contact Bob, KA8IAF for info 419-795-5763 (pre-register)	Sep 25
Nov 27	EXAMS Van Wert EMA 2 PM Contact Walt, WB8FNB for info 419-394-2976 (pre-register)	WD8MLV

NEWS & notes

Sorry to hear that Zane, K8IVN had a stroke in mid-May. We sure do miss you on the 75 Mtr net and at club activities Zane. Hope you are better and can be back on the air real soon. Our prayers are with you and I'm sure you will make it back.

It's nice to have Barb, N8GFK and Bob, KA8IAF back from AZ. Thanks to Bob for getting out the labels for the mailing.

And thanks to Walt, WB8FNB for taking of the VE duties this past winter. You folks do a great job, and it is appreciated.

Keep in mind that the testing is the fourth Saturday of the scheduled month at 2:00 PM and they would sure appreciate pre-registration. Check the future dates in the VWARC Cal

Continuing with the Thanks, Farm Focus has been generous to the VWARC again this year. We should all realize that those of you who have helped with the setup and operation and tare down of Farm Focus make this donation possible. So thanks to you, and keep up the good work there will room for new help at FF too.

Abig thanks to Mike, K8PBE for his continuing work with the WEB site. Bob, WD8LPY has got the paper work in order for things ((?)) and it's up and running. So check out w8fy.org and you have something to get on there get it to Mike.

We hope you didn't forget anything this year, but it could have slipped your mind. I know there are lots of things going on, and it's Spring time! So you could have forgotten something? "Like what", you say? ☺

YOUR DUES TO THE VWARC that's what! ☺
It won't take you long to do it and the way to keep the dues at \$10 is for everyone to pay. If you have missed out for awhile that's OK and if you want to join we can handle that also. Send to;
The Van Wert Amateur Radio Club Inc.
P.O. Box 602, Van Wert, OH 45891

OR BETTER YET BRING IT TO A MEETING
AND PUT IT IN JACK'S HAND!

Yes, Ezamarelda gets a very weak voice at times and right in the storm season. The fix will be coming, it's all approved and such but the paper work takes a lot of time! Do the best you can to live with the old girl a little longer. Turn up the gain and stay on 85 because we need everyone active during this season, it's part of our reason for being! You can prove how good an operator you are by making it work. 146.85 is the place we need you and don't forget you may need to monitor 146.70 and 444.85 to make communications happen. Perhaps even simplex O MY lions and tigers and bears!

Do we have a retirement party planed for Ezamarelda? We may need help Michele!

Welcome home also to Jim, WA8WKD and Carol; also Bob, K8RZN and Betty, K8SQO and Clarence, WB8EHJ. Nice to have you'll back from the south. They and others get on 14317 Khz to look for K7ZKL at the summer quarters in Walker, AZ who always is looking for the folks in Van Wert area, he would like to hear from you too! I hope condx get better.

As we are putting this Open Squelch together on Memorial Day I hope everyone in their own way has taken the time to REMEMBER and HONOR all who have served our country now and in history. The dedication to country that they do and have displayed is all the more reason to be thankful and proud of this country.

Just to prove how old I am, I still remember the year at Field Day that all operating stopped, except for the generators that kept the TV running so everyone could sit and watch "Gun Smoke".

We'll hope we do better than that this year as we defend our record setting first place finish in the 4Fclass at FD 2004. Hope to see you all there you are all welcome at the EMA/W8FY location at the Marsh Foundation in Van Wert.

The ARRL is still the only National Organization working for Ham Radio, join and give support to the League and get QST FREE!

Weather Related Reference Guide

For Emergency Personnel

This guide was put together to provide Emergency Managers, Dispatchers, Police and Sheriff Officers, Fire Fighters, and other county and state officials with weather information that is critical to both your local agency and the National Weather Service (NWS). Timely information freely shared between your agency and the NWS can literally mean the difference between life and death.

Critical weather information is broken down into categories for easy reference below. When providing a report please provide the following information

1. Who you are
2. Location and time of event
3. What was seen and/or damage witnessed.

Tornados	Flooding	Winter Weather
• Tornados • Funnel Cloud • Rotating Wall Cloud	• Flooding that results in evacuations • High water rescues from roofs or trees • Water: ○ rapidly rising ○ entering homes, not just basements • Roads: ○ closed due to high water ○ impassable due to high water • Small Streams overflowing their banks. • $\geq 1"$ of rain measured, in an hour	• Any Freezing Rain or Drizzle • Thunder associated with Snow, Sleet, or Freezing Rain • $>1"$ of Snow accumulation.
Severe Thunderstorm • Any size Hail-Severe Hail Is $\frac{3}{4}$ inch • Wind damage to trees, Power lines, or any structure		

Hail Estimates (inches)	Wind Speed Estimates (mph)
• Pea 0.25 • Penny 0.75 • Quarter 1.00 • Half-Dollar 1.25 • Walnut 1.50 • Golf Ball 1.75 • Tennis Ball 2.50 • Baseball 2.75 • Grapefruit 4.00	• 39-54 Small limbs break off trees • 55-72 Downed shallow rooted trees, minor structural damage • 73-112 Minor to major structural damage, Trailers overturned • 113+ Major structural damage, Trailers destroyed

Information You Can Use:

Phone Numbers

NWS Northern Indiana – 1-888-668-3344 (unlisted and only for severe reports)

Public Information line – 1-574-834-1104

Web Site – <http://www.crh.noaa.gov/iwx>

Headline Definitions:

- **Hazardous Weather Outlook** – Potential for significant weather for the next 7 days.
- **Watch** – Conditions are favorable for weather event in or near the watch area. Watches may be issued for weather events listed under Warnings.
- **Warning** – Weather Event is imminent or occurring in warned area.
 - **Tornado** – A violently rotating column of air extending from a thunderstorm and in contact with the ground.
 - **Severe Thunderstorm** – Thunderstorm that produces hail $\geq \frac{3}{4}$ " and/or wind gusts ≥ 58 mph.
 - **Flash Flood** – Rapid rise of water resulting in:
 1. Rushing water over roads,
 2. Water entering main level of homes and businesses, and/or
 3. A dam break.
 - **Flood** – Rise of water that results in water covering roads or spilling out of stream banks. Not as rapid or extreme as flash flooding.
 - **Winter Weather** –
 - **Blizzard** –
 1. Sustained wind or frequent gusts ≥ 35 mph accompanied by falling and/or
 2. Blowing snow, frequently reducing visibilities $\leq \frac{1}{4}$ mile for 3 or more hours.
 - **Snow** – 6" in 12 hours or 8" in 24 hours.
 - **Ice** – $\geq \frac{1}{4}$ " in 24 hours
 - **Wind Chill** – $\leq -30^{\circ}\text{F}$ with wind > 10 mph.
 - **Heat** –
 - Heat Index ≥ 110 for 3 hours or more
 - **High Wind** – Sustained wind blowing at 40 mph and/or gust to 58 mph.
- **Advisory**
 - **Winter Weather** –
 - **Snow** – Average of 4" in 12 hours.
 - **Ice** – $< \frac{1}{4}$ " in 24 hours
 - **Snow and Blowing Snow** – Sustained wind or frequent gust of 25 to 34 mph and falling and blowing snow, which occasionally reduces visibility to ≤ 1 mile for at least an hour.
 - **Blowing Snow** – Widespread or localized blowing snow reducing visibilities to ≤ 1 mile for at least an hour and winds 25 to 34 mph.
 - **Wind Chill** – -20 to -29°F with wind > 10 mph.
 - **Heat** –
 - Heat index of 100-109 for 3 hours or more
 - **Wind** – Sustained wind blowing 31 to 39 mph for an hour or more and/or gust 46 to 57 mph.
 - **Dense Fog** – Widespread Visibilities $\leq \frac{1}{4}$ mile.

Delphos Firemen's Convention set for June 18, 19

W8FY has received an invitation from the Tri-County Radio Club, W8YEK, to help out with all the activities associated with the Delphos Firemen's Association Convention to be held on June 18 and 19th on Main Street in Delphos.

At press time we don't have all of the particulars, but Bob, W8ULM put forth the invite to W8FY members to help out with communications for their events. Be listening on both the Van Wert and Delphos machines for more information.

Hey, like we *need* a good excuse to go to the Creamery?

Holiday at Home festivities are set

Van Wert's Holiday at Home Festival will be here before we know it. On July 4th, activities start early with pancakes and sausage breakfast and end with fireworks. The radio club traditionally helps with the parade at 11:00 am July 4th and then settles into operating a special events station amid the vendors and the little red caboose at the Van Wert County Historical Society grounds on North Washington Street. With the holiday falling on a Sunday, the annual Firecracker Century Bike Tour will be held the following day, July 5th. That event, sponsored by the Van Wert Bicycle Club, begins and ends at Jubilee Park. Hams are needed along the route for safety sake, and as always, the more the merrier.

New 85 machine is closer

Van Wert County Director of Homeland Security and Emergency Management Rick McCoy, KB8LFJ, says bids will be awarded soon for the purchase of a new repeater to replace the aging and ailing 85 machine.

There have been some delays due to the coordinating of the bidding process with various agencies, but things are a "go" now for the new equipment, according to Rick.

A new repeater and duplexers will be purchased and the equipment will be installed at the current repeater location near Van Wert. As yet there are no firm plans for the old equipment, which is county property. But what do you do with 30-year-old GE Progress Line equipment, other than find someone who is nursing along an old repeater and needs some spare parts? Ezamarelda has served us well.

-----by Jack Snyder, WD8MLV

FCC Extends BPL Reply Comments Filing Deadline

NEWINGTON, CT, May 27, 2004--The FCC has extended the deadline to file reply comments in its broadband over power line (BPL) proceeding, ET Docket 04-37, from Tuesday, June 1, to Tuesday, June 22. The Commission released its BPL Notice of Proposed Rule Making (NPRM) February 23, and the initial comment deadline passed May 3. The FCC acted on a request from the National Antenna Consortium and the Amherst Alliance (NAC/Amherst) for a much longer filing deadline extension. The NAC/Amherst petition cited the anticipated release of the National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA) Phase 2 BPL study in making its request for a filing delay. The organizations said the FCC was not allowing stakeholders adequate time to prepare comments to address the two-part NTIA report on BPL interference. The FCC said the NTIA has indicated that it will submit comments and a technical appendix in the BPL proceeding this week. Those submissions are expected to contain key findings of the Phase 2 report, due to be released later this year. "We believe that three weeks should provide ample time for review and analysis of this information, and accordingly grant the extension for that period," said FCC Office of Engineering and Technology Chief Edmond J. Thomas, who signed the Order Granting Extension of Time released May 27. NAC/Amherst had sought to have the FCC postpone the filing comment deadline until either September 1 or two months after the public release of the NTIA's Phase 2 study--whichever was later. The FCC said the groups "presented no specific justification for such a longer time, nor is one evident to us." The FCC said the additional three weeks should be "ample time" to respond to the anticipated NTIA submission "as long as it is filed reasonably close to the anticipated date of May 28. Noting that its Part 15 rules already permit Access BPL systems and that its BPL *NPRM* places additional requirements on BPL systems over and above what Part 15 already requires, the FCC said to further delay the proceeding would diminish the Commission's ability to protect licensed users now occupying the HF spectrum. In addition, the FCC said, a further extension "would needlessly increase regulatory uncertainty about this technology's promise to deliver broadband services" to US consumers.

The FCC *Order* turned down a request that the FCC reissue in a substantially more detailed form the provisions of its proposed BPL rules concerning interference prevention and mitigation and the enforcement of standards. The FCC said that NAC/Amherst provided no compelling reason nor did it suggest how the FCC's proposed rules were insufficiently described.

The FCC does not routinely grant such time extensions, and it denied earlier petitions, including filings from the ARRL and NAC/Amherst, to extend the initial comment filing deadline, which was May 3. The League and others said commenters needed more time to digest the NTIA's Part 1 BPL study, released April 27.

Earlier this year, FCC Chairman Michael K. Powell turned down a request by US Rep Greg Walden, W7EQI, to delay further action on the BPL proceeding until the NTIA study's had been released and stakeholders had had a chance to evaluate it before commenting.

Connecticut Attorney Don Schellhardt is a co-founder of The Amherst Alliance and served as its first national coordinator. He's the NAC's vice president for government relations and membership development and an associate ARRL member.

For more information on BPL, visit the "Broadband Over Power Line (BPL) and Amateur Radio" page on the ARRL Web site.

D-Day Museum special event set

(May 31, 2004) -- The Jefferson Amateur Radio Club will mark the 60th anniversary of D-Day--the Allied invasion of Normandy--with special event Station W5D Saturday and Sunday, June 5-6. W5D will operate from the main floor of the National D-Day Museum in New Orleans. The station will be on the air from 1400 to 2300 UTC each day.

"We will be operating from the Museum as well as providing a display of World War II vintage radio gear, a tape of the first 16 minutes of a radio broadcast describing the invasion as it happened, and eyeball ragchews," said Jefferson ARC Vice President Keith Barnes, W5KB. The group is seeking a few additional pieces of period radio gear for display purposes only. A few operator slots remain. Contact Barnes, w5kb@cox.net via e-mail for details. A certificate will be available for those contacting W5D. Include \$2.50 for postage and handling (or include an SASE for a QSL card). Certificate/QSL requests go to the Jefferson Amateur Radio Club, W5GAD, PO Box 73665, Metairie, LA LA 70033.

-----from the ARRL Letter

Astronaut Ham logs space station first contact

NEWINGTON, CT, May 27, 2004--NASA Expedition 9 International Space Station Science Officer and Flight Engineer Mike Fincke, KE5AIT, logged what's believed to be his first-ever Amateur Radio contact May 25 from the spacecraft's NA1SS. The QSO also marked the first Amateur Radio on the International Space Station (ARISS) school group contact for the Expedition 9 crew. The US astronaut and Russian cosmonaut and Expedition 9 Commander Gennady Padalka, RN3DT, arrived aboard the ISS in late April and have been settling in. Fincke advised a dozen youngsters gathered at Erie Planetarium in Pennsylvania, that one of the first tasks he and Padalka must undertake is a space walk. The crew needs to replace a failed remote power controller module for one of the four ISS control moment gyroscopes, or CMGs.

"I'm really looking forward to it," Fincke told the youngsters, who attend several schools in the Erie area. The space walk should take place in the next couple of weeks or so, he said. NASA managers decided this week that Fincke and Padalka will use the Russian *Orlan* space suits for their "extra-vehicular activity" or EVA. The crew's efforts to troubleshoot and repair cooling system problems in the US EVA Mobility Units were not successful, the space agency said. In addition to the CMG repair EVA, the Expedition 9 crew will carry out two other space walks during their six-month tour.

Responding to another question, Fincke said he's really enjoying the weightlessness of space, although he noted, some caution is in order. "I love being weightless," he said. "I can fly around like Superman and pick up very big things." He cautioned, however, that crew members need to "take it nice and easy" in weightlessness to avoid banging into things and injuring themselves.

For fun and recreation, Fincke said, the crew has laptop computers and can watch DVDs--although there's no television aboard. "The whole space station is a little bit fun to play in and do fun things," he said, "but just being aboard the International Space Station is like a dream come true, so it's all fun--every minute of every day is really fun." He pointed out in answer to a later question that the 180-ton space station has "lots of room," especially for a crew of only two people.

Fincke also explained that even though the crew can't take baths or showers "we do wash ourselves carefully every day--maybe even twice a day depending on how many times we do our exercises" using wet washcloths. As for washing clothes, he said, they don't. "We just use our clothes for a little bit longer than you do on the planet and then we just throw them away." The ISS has no bathtubs, showers, sinks or microwaves aboard, he said.

In all, the youngsters asked 18 questions of Fincke before the ISS went over the horizon from the telebridge station of Tony Hutchison, VK5ZAI, in South Australia. MCI donated a teleconferencing link to handle the two-way audio between VK5ZAI and the planetarium.

Fincke has twice before visited the Erie Planetarium, which is run by the Erie County Historical Society. "Visit your local planetarium," he advised the students as the QSO came to a conclusion. Assisting Planetarium Director Jim Gavio during the ARISS contact were Ron Prindle, N3BXL, Paul Semrau, N3UMM, Jim Tolbert Jr, WW3S, and Jim Tolbert III, KB3IXG. Will Marchant, KC6ROL, moderated the event.

ARISS is an international educational outreach program with US participation by ARRL, NASA and AMSAT.

-----from the ARRL Website

The Van Wert Amateur Radio Club
Box 602
Van Wert, Ohio 45891